

"STUDENTS NOW GET ADDED COURSE OPTIONS TO MAKE THEM MORE EMPLOYABLE"

In alignment with the National Education Policy 2020, the University Grants Commission (UGC) introduced a series of reforms for higher education institutions or HEIs. These student-centric reforms focus on a new curriculum framework, a multidisciplinary approach, modern pedagogy and transparent regulations. In an exclusive interview with Executive Editor KAUSHIK DEKA, UGC Chairman M. JAGADESH KUMAR elaborates on the reforms undertaken by the higher education regulator and outlines a future roadmap. Edited excerpts from the interview.

Q. What are the significant reforms the UGC has initiated since you took charge in 2022?

The ministry of education and the country's educational institutions are collaborating on higher education reforms, with the UGC acting as a facilitator. One of the primary objectives is to provide freedom and flexibility to students. Technology enables us to collect data on learning outcomes, helping identify areas that need improvement, leading to policy interventions. One such initiative encourages institutions to adopt multidisciplinary education without concerns about funding and infrastructure.

We have also introduced new curriculum frameworks for undergraduate and postgraduate courses, offering significant flexibility. For example, students interested in studying medieval history can earn academic credits in insurance or risk management, enhancing their employment opportunities. Today, a large majority of the 43 million students pursue BA, BSc or BCom degrees. The UGC aims to make these undergraduate students employable by offering courses in artificial intelligence, machine learning, banking, finance and management, in addition to their regular discipline.

Postgraduate courses also offer flexibility. For instance, a commerce graduate can opt for an MA in applied mathematics by clearing a national entrance test and earning credits through SWAYAM online modules. In fact, we are also focusing on enhancing access to higher education through online means. The SWAYAM platform offers over 3,000 courses. Up to 40 per cent of undergraduate degree programme credits